Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

Excel

A Conditional Formatting Problem

Say you're having a problem getting your conditional formatting to work as desired with information imported into Excel from Access. The data being imported in a particular column can either be text (such as "17 U") or numeric (such as "32"). The conditional format checks to see if the value in the cell is greater than zero, in which case the value is underlined. This won't work properly with the imported data because not only does Excel treat the text ("17 U") as text, but it also treats the numeric ("32") as text. This makes sense, since Excel treats the entire column as text rather than changing data format for each cell in the column. There are a couple of ways you can fix this problem. One is to change the formula you are using in your conditional format. Instead of checking to see if the value is greater than zero, use the following formula (set the conditional check to "Format Is"):

=VALUE(E3) > 0

This formula uses the VALUE function to check what is in cell E3. If the contents are a number—even if it is formatted as text by Excel—then the formula returns True, and the condition is met for the formatting. If the contents of E3 really are text (as in "17 U"), then the formula returns a #VALUE error, which does not satisfy the condition, and the formatting is not applied.

Another approach is to force Excel to evaluate the imported cells and convert them to numeric values, if appropriate. An easy way to do this is as follows: after importing the data, select a blank cell from a column outside the range of those you just imported. Press [Ctrl] + [C]. Select the cells that you want evaluated by Excel. For instance, select the column that contains the text values and the numeric values formatted as text. Choose Paste Special from the Edit menu. Click the 'Add' radio button and click 'OK'.

What you just did was to "add" the contents of the Clipboard to all the cells you selected. If the cells contained real text, then nothing happened to those cells; they remain the same and are still treated as text. If the cells contained a numeric value, then Excel treats it as a number and adds zero to it. This value, as a numeric, is deposited back in the cell, and treated as a real number. This means that the conditional formatting test that you previously set up should work just fine on those cells since they are no longer treated as text.

Copying Conditional Formatting

In Excel, conditional formatting is considered part of the regular formatting of a cell. If you want to copy conditional formatting from one cell to another, you can do so by simply copying the cell and pasting it (or its format) to another cell. If you want to copy a conditional format to a range of cells (and only the conditional format), the easiest way to do so is this: select the range to which you want the conditional format copied. Make sure, however, that the cell whose conditional format you want copied is part of the range. Choose 'Conditional Format' from the 'Format' menu. You will see the 'Conditional Format' dialog box. The format should already be filled in. Click 'OK'. Excel does the rest and copies the conditional formatting, as you desired.

What Are Add-Ins?

Many features of Excel are available only through what are called add-ins, for instance, the Analysis ToolPak. The tools available in add-ins are not part of the basic Excel system, but can be added to the system as and when needed. Add-ins are programs that have been "added to" Excel in such a way that they appear to be part of Excel itself.

You can find many useful add-ins for Excel on the Net.

Excel allows you to translate your macro programs into add-ins. Converting them to add-ins has several advantages:

1. The program code cannot be altered by others.
2. The program code runs a bit quicker.
3. The add-in is available without needing to open any particular workbook.
4. The functions provided by the add-in appear to be a part of Excel.

Add-ins are, therefore, a special type of workbook that you've converted to a format understood by Excel.

Creating An Add-In

Any Excel workbook can be converted to an add-in. To create a protected add-in file, first load the workbook that will become your add-in. Start the Visual Basic Editor by choosing Macro from the Tools menu, then choosing Visual Basic Editor. At the very top of the Project window, select the bold entry that declares the name of the VBA project that is open. Choose the Properties option from the Tools menu. This displays the Project Properties dialog box. Make sure the Protection tab is selected, and make sure the 'Lock Project For Viewing' checkbox is selected. Enter a password in both fields at the bottom of the dialog box. Click 'OK'—the dialog box closes.

Close the Visual Basic Editor and return to the Excel workbook. Choose File > Properties. In the Summary tab, make sure the 'Title' field is filled in. What you enter here will appear in the 'Add-Ins' dialog box used by Excel. Make sure the 'Comments' field is filled in. What you enter here will appear in the description area of the 'Add-Ins' dialog box used by Excel. Click 'OK' to close the dialog box. Now choose 'Save As'. Using the 'Save As Type' pull-down list, specify the Microsoft Excel Add-In (*.xla) file type. Specify a name in the 'File Name' field. Click 'Save'. Your add-in file has been created. Finally, close the workbook you just saved as an add-in.

Using An Add-In

After you have created your own add-in, you can use it in your system. Once the add-in has been loaded, the functions or features in the add-in become available to any other workbook you may have open, or any time you are using Excel. To use your add-in, choose 'Add-Ins' from